FT FollowThrough

The HVAC Playbook

What to say from the first call to the five-star review. Copy the lines, put them in your own words, and keep this on your phone.

1. The first call or message

Sound calm, understand the job, and book a next step. Ask:

- What's it doing: not cooling, not heating, a strange noise, or water around the unit?
- Is anyone at risk without heat or cooling, like a baby, an older person or a pet? If so, book the first slot.
- How old is the system, and when was it last serviced?
- Can you send a photo of the label on the outdoor unit and the furnace?

> "Thanks for calling [Business], this is [Name]. Tell me what the system's doing and I'll see how we can help."

> "My diagnostic visit is [price], and it comes off the repair if you go ahead. I can be there today at 3 or tomorrow at 9. Which works better?"

2. Presenting the quote

- Show the readings and photos first: what you measured and what failed.
- Price the repair from your flat-rate book, and when replacement makes sense, show both prices side by side.
- For replacements, offer two or three options (standard and higher efficiency), sized from a load calculation, not a guess.
- Itemize equipment, coil, line set, permit, labor and warranty, and say who registers the warranty.

> "Here's what I found, here are the readings, and here's what it costs to repair or replace. If you'd like to go ahead, I can do it Thursday. What questions do you have?"

3. The 7 objections HVAC techs hear and what to say

Acknowledge it, ask a question, answer honestly, suggest a next step.

1. "The other company quoted less."
"That's fair, I'd compare too. Is it the same size and efficiency, with a new coil, line set and permit? That's where HVAC quotes differ. I'll leave you a short checklist so you can compare them side by side."

2. "I want to get a couple more quotes."
"Makes sense for a system that should last 12–15 years. What will you compare on? Ask each company whether they did a load calculation, what efficiency rating they quoted and who registers the warranty. I'll call Thursday to answer any questions."

3. "Can you do it for less?"
"I can quote a standard-efficiency option or keep parts that are still in good shape. What budget are you working with? I won't skip the permit or proper refrigerant work, because that keeps it safe and under warranty."

4. "Can't you just add refrigerant?"
"I could, but refrigerant doesn't get used up, so low refrigerant means a leak. Has it needed a top-up before? I'll check how fast it's leaking and show you the price to find and fix it next to the price to replace, so you can choose."

5. “I’ll wait until it dies completely.”
“I get it, nobody wants to replace something that still runs. How old is it, and has it needed repairs lately? Systems often fail on the hottest day, when installers are booked out. I’ll quote it now so you can plan, and keep it running until you’re ready.”

6. “How do I know you’re not just selling me a new system?”
“Fair question, it happens in this trade. What would help you trust the diagnosis? I’ll show you the readings and photos and price the repair too. If repairing makes more sense, I’ll tell you so.”

7. “Why do you need money up front?”
“The deposit buys your equipment so it’s held for your install date. What payment schedule works for you? It’s all in the contract, and the balance is due once the system is running and you’ve signed off.”

4. Follow up: day 2, day 5, day 12

Most quotes go quiet, not “no”. Keep each message short and useful.

> **Day 2:** “Hi [Name], it’s [Your name] from [Business]. Did the quote for your system come through okay? Happy to go through the options with you.”

> **Day 5:** “Hi [Name], checking in on your [AC/furnace]. I have an install opening on [day] and can hold it for you until Friday.”

> **Day 12:** “Hi [Name], I’ll close out your quote on Friday. If you’d still like to go ahead, or just keep the old system running for now, reply and I’ll help either way.”

Many people decide after the next heat wave or cold snap. When one is on the forecast, a short “Is the system keeping up?” text gets replies.

5. Ask for the review and the referral

Ask right after the job, when they’re happiest, and text a direct link to your Google review page.

> “Thanks again, [Name]. If you’re happy with the work, would you leave a quick Google review? I’ll text you the link. And if a neighbor’s system is acting up, I’d be glad to take a look.”

Before you leave, offer a spring and fall tune-up. A maintenance customer calls you, not a stranger, when something breaks.

Three rules that keep you out of trouble

- Pull the permit and install equipment that meets your area’s refrigerant and efficiency rules, or you may redo it at your cost.
- Only handle refrigerant with EPA 608 certification, and check your state’s HVAC license before you quote.
- Put equipment, ductwork, electrical, permit and warranty registration in writing, with a clause for hidden problems priced per item.

General education, not legal, tax or insurance advice. Rules and prices vary by state, so check yours.
The full start-up guide for HVAC techs: followthroughguides.com/hvac · Questions: info@followthroughguides.com